

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 227

By McNally

A RESOLUTION to recognize and honor St. Mary's School on the occasion of its seventy-fifth anniversary.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should recognize those exemplary educational institutions that have made significant contributions, through an abiding commitment to excellence, to their respective communities and to this State; and

WHEREAS, one such noteworthy institution is St. Mary's School of Oak Ridge, which is celebrating its seventy-fifth anniversary of operation this year; and

WHEREAS, the story of St. Mary's is intertwined with that of St. Mary Parish; when the U.S. government situated its major wartime project in the East Tennessee mountains in the 1940s and Oak Ridge, "the Secret City," was born, hundreds of workers and scientists flocked to the area to staff the city's several large nuclear plants; and

WHEREAS, the initial inhabitants of Oak Ridge came from diverse backgrounds, cultures, traditions, and locations, and many of them were Catholic, which necessitated the establishment of a parish and, subsequently, a school for the children of the residents; and

WHEREAS, St. Mary Parish and St. Mary's School shared a vital role in the development and direction of their community; in 1949 and 1950, the parcel of land upon which the parish and school now sit was purchased, and on September 10, 1950, St. Mary's School opened its doors to 200 students; and

WHEREAS, originally home to grades one through six, grades seven and eight were added in the school's second year of operation, and kindergarten began in the 1983-1984 academic year; and

WHEREAS, the pre-kindergarten program started in the fall of 1985, and the school reached its current complement of grades with the addition of a pre-school, three-year-old program in 2017; and

WHEREAS, improvements to St. Mary's School over the years include the addition of a primary science lab and complete primary science curriculum for grades pre-K through five in 1999; the lab is the only one of its kind in the area and is still one of the few in the entire State. A total physical renovation of the school, to include a new gymnasium, was completed in September 2000; and

WHEREAS, in 2010, St. Mary's School was declared a Blue Ribbon School of Excellence by the U.S. Department of Education, placing it in the top ten percent of schools in the nation academically; and

WHEREAS, from its inception, the school was staffed by the Dominican Sisters of St. Cecilia from Nashville, a tradition that continues to this day; and

WHEREAS, St. Mary's School has long enjoyed the teaching services of educators of the greatest dedication, ability, and integrity and a staff committed to the highest ideals of public service and quality education for all; and

WHEREAS, the dedication to academic excellence demonstrated by all the fine individuals affiliated with St. Mary's School is clearly deserving of our respect, admiration, and commendation on this most auspicious occasion; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor St. Mary's School of Oak Ridge on the occasion of its seventy-fifth anniversary, commend its administration, faculty, staff, and students, both past and present, for their dedication to the highest tenets of education, and extend to them our best wishes for much continued success.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.